play for, a team in the summer league, so I'd come to games with him. We'd practice together before and after and then, while his match was taking place on the big field, I'd find some other boys to play with on the cinder next door. I've had most of my professional career at a club with the best facilities and where everything's taken care of, but I'm glad I had the experience of a place like Wadham Lodge when I was a boy. I mean, if I'd not been there with my dad, I might have grown up never knowing about Soap on a Rope. More to the point, it was where I started taking free-kicks. After everybody else had finished and was in the social club, I'd stand on the edge of the penalty area and chip a dead ball towards goal. Every time I hit the bar was worth 50 pence extra pocket money from my dad that week. And, just as important, a pat on the back.

The other dads might bring their boys along sometimes but, once I started, I was there week in and week out. I'd sit in the bar and watch the men training and then, towards the end of the session, they'd let me join in with the five-a-sides. I was so excited to be out there playing with the rest of them —these grown men—that I took whatever I had coming. I do remember an occasion when one of them came flying into me with a tackle and Dad wasn't happy about it at all but, usually, if I took a knock he'd just tell me to get up and get on with it. He warned me that I had to be prepared to get a bit roughed up now and again. If he'd been running around telling people not to tackle me all evening, it would have been pointless me being there in the first place. The fact that I always seemed to be playing soccer with players who were bigger and stronger than me when I was young, I'm sure, helped me later on in my career.

On the nights when I wasn't at Wadham Lodge, I'd be in Chase Lane Park. We had this secret cut-through to get there: across the road and then four or five houses down from my mum and dad's where there was a private alley. We'd wait around at the top of it until there was nobody about and then sprint fifty yards to the hedge, then through it and the hole in the fence. I still have one or two friends who I first met in Chase Lane. I went on to school with Simon Treglowen and his brother Matt, and I'm still in touch with Simon now. We decided we got on all right after one particular row about whether or not I'd scored past him in goal. That turned into a big fight, even though Simon's four years older than me. Fighting: it's a funny way boys have of making friends. Usually we'd just kick a ball around until it got dark, but there also used to be a youth club, in a little hut, run by a lady called Joan. My mum knew her and would phone up to say we were on our way over. You could play table tennis or pool and get a fizzy drink or some chocolate. There was an outdoor paddling pool at the back that got filled up in the summer.